

ACEP Supports Standardized Medical Emoji for Clearer Health Communication

Why the College is backing an effort to bring the language of medicine to the emoji keyboard on every phone.

Presented by the ACEP Emergency Medicine Informatics Section.

Emergency physicians communicate under time pressure, often with patients who speak different languages, read at different levels, and arrive in moments of crisis. In that environment, a clear visual anchor can do real work. That is the premise behind the [Medical Emoji Project](#), an effort to add high-utility medical symbols to the Unicode Standard — the global system behind the emoji that appear on virtually every smartphone, tablet, and computer. The American College of Emergency Physicians has now issued a [formal letter of support](#) for that work.

A communication layer, not a replacement

Standardized medical emoji are meant to add a familiar, globally available layer for patient education, discharge instructions, public health messaging, medical education, and informal patient–provider communication. They are not a substitute for clinical language or professional interpretation. The value is in giving common clinical concepts — organ systems, infection, cardiac monitoring, transfusion, medication use, and weight-based care — a simple, shared symbol that travels across languages, literacy levels, ages, and disabilities.

For the informatics community, the appeal is structural. Emoji are already a standardized, cross-platform character set with stable code points and broad rendering support. Extending that set toward clinical concepts means a consistent visual vocabulary that downstream systems — messaging, patient portals, education materials — can rely on without bespoke iconography.

The approach already has a proven precedent

This is not a hypothetical. In 2019, emergency physician [Shuhan He, MD](#) and collaborators helped submit the anatomical heart and lungs to Unicode. Both were accepted into Unicode 14.0 and shipped on billions of devices in 2021, and the effort was documented in *JAMA*. That success showed the medical community can successfully navigate a rigorous international standards process — and it set the template for what comes next.

Ten concepts now in development

ACEP's letter names ten concepts the project is pursuing, each tied to a substantial clinical and public-health footprint:

- **Liver** — liver disease causes roughly 2 million deaths a year worldwide.
- **Kidney** — chronic kidney disease affects about 10% of the global population.
- **Stomach** — GERD carries an estimated \$18 billion in direct annual costs.
- **Intestine / bowel** — colorectal cancer is the second-leading cause of cancer death.
- **White blood cell** — a symbol for infection and immunity, from everyday illness to pandemics.
- **ECG / EKG** — one person dies of cardiovascular disease every 36 seconds in the U.S.
- **Spine** — low back pain is the leading cause of years lived with disability worldwide.
- **Blood product** — in the U.S., someone needs blood roughly every two seconds.
- **Pill pack** — a marker for medication use and adherence amid the opioid crisis.
- **Weight scale** — more than 2 billion people worldwide live with overweight or obesity.

A complete view of each concept, along with the [full list of supporting organizations](#), is available on the project's site.

How the standards process works

Unicode evaluates emoji proposals through a formal, published process. Each proposal must satisfy criteria including distinctiveness, expected frequency of use, image licensing, and broad applicability. Professional and clinical letters of support speak directly to that last point: they help demonstrate that a proposed symbol carries real-world relevance across a

wide population. Petitions and awareness campaigns, by contrast, are explicitly not counted as usage evidence — which is part of why a society's measured, professional support matters.

What ACEP's support adds

ACEP's support is clinical and professional. It reflects a judgment that these concepts are relevant to emergency care and could help clinicians and patients communicate more effectively in modern digital environments. As a national, multi-specialty body, the College's support speaks to the broad applicability that the standards process weighs — and signals that the goal is better representation of medicine and health in the tools people already use every day.

Learn more: Explore the concepts and every letter of support at medicalemoji.org and medicalemoji.org/endorsements. Read ACEP's [letter of support](#).